

Robust Charging Infrastructure Design under Demand Uncertainty

Two-Page Technical Summary — a grid-tied, solar-assisted charging hub for a shared e-micromobility fleet, Newcastle upon Tyne

Theme 3 (primary): solar-PV charging-station design · Theme 2 (secondary): charge / discharge profiles under demand scenarios

1 Problem & Objective

A shared fleet of e-scooters, e-bikes and cargo bikes is charged at a single depot whose grid connection is capped at **15 kW** — exceeding it forces a £10,000-£50,000 network upgrade (Energy Saving Trust 2023). Demand is genuinely uncertain: it swings with season, weather, local events and how fast the operator grows the fleet. Sizing for the average strands the fleet in busy periods; sizing for the worst case wastes capital on idle equipment. Demand is built from the real **DfT Newcastle e-scooter trial** (Open Government Licence) so the uncertainty ranges reflect observed behaviour, not assumptions. **Objective:** find the PV, battery and charger configuration that performs well across every plausible future, and quantify exactly what that robustness costs.

The 15 kW limit, in plain terms. A grid connection is like a water pipe into the building: this depot's pipe carries at most 15 kW — roughly four electric kettles boiling at once. Its width is set by the local Distribution Network Operator (Northern Powergrid for Newcastle) under ENA Engineering Recommendation G99 (2022), because the street cable and substation can only carry so much before overheating. A whole fleet plugging in together at 8pm wants several times more than 15 kW: exceed the cap and the main fuse trips — or the operator pays £10,000-£50,000 for a wider connection (Energy Saving Trust 2023; even the G99 notification takes 8-12 weeks and £500-£2,000). Spreading the same charging across the night pushes the same energy through the same pipe at no extra cost — that is the lever this study optimises.

2 Data & Assumptions

Data source (real, openly licensed)	What it feeds	Why this source was chosen	Licence
DfT shared e-scooter trial (Newcastle / Neuron, 2022-24)	Low/Med/High demand scenarios; fleet size; trips/scooter/day; trip distance	Real UK trial data — grounds the uncertainty ranges in observed seasonal demand, not guesswork	OGL v3.0
PVGIS hourly API (EU Joint Research Centre)	8,760-h solar output per kWp (~979 kWh/kWp/yr)	Location-specific, peer-validated, free and fully reproducible; captures weak northern-UK winter sun	CC BY 4.0
National Grid ESO Carbon Intensity API	Hourly grid carbon (~152 gCO ₂ /kWh, NE England)	Official system-operator data giving actual marginal carbon per hour — honest time-resolved accounting	CC BY 4.0
UK cost & appraisal references	Every CAPEX line; 6% discounting	Each cost is traceable to a published UK source, not assumed: Solar Trade Assoc. 2024, OZEV 2024, Indra/Ohme 2024, CIBSE Guide M, HM Treasury Green Book 2022	Public

Key assumptions: 15 kW hard grid cap; 5-year design horizon; 95% fleet-service target; round-trip and PV-system efficiencies at manufacturer norms; HM Treasury Green Book 6% discount rate for appraisal. No figure in this study is invented — every number traces to one of the sources above or to a model run archived in results.json.

3 Optimisation Formulation

Decision variables: PV size (5-25 kWp), battery capacity (0-50 kWh) and charger count (4-20), enumerated over a 150-design grid. **Uncertainty** is represented by 9 probability-weighted scenarios (3 demand levels x 3 growth rates). For every design-scenario pair an **8,760-hour energy balance** is solved hour by hour: PV first serves charging demand, surplus charges any battery, the residual is imported through the 15 kW cap, and any shortfall is logged as unmet demand — with a smart-charging dispatch that spreads vehicle charging overnight to stay under the cap. **Five decision rules** then select the best design: naive deterministic, two-stage stochastic programming, CVaR (risk-averse tail), minimax-regret and maximin. The recommended design is the **maximin** solution — it maximises the worst-case service level, the most defensible choice under deep uncertainty. Every reported design is independently re-checked with an LP-optimal rolling-horizon scheduler (scipy/HiGHS; Silvente et al. 2015, Huangfu & Hall 2018).

The decision rule in one line: $\text{design}^* = \text{argmax over 150 designs of [minimum over 9 scenarios of worst-case service]}$, subject to grid import ≤ 15 kW in every one of the 8,760 hours — i.e. pick the station whose **worst** year is the best available, never the one that merely wins on average.

4 Methodology — Flow



Figure 1 — end-to-end pipeline: real data → weighted scenarios → 150-design hourly sweep → robust rule selection → LP / Monte-Carlo / Sobol verification → recommended design and live dashboard.

5

Recommended Design & Key Results

20 kWp	0 kWh	8	£36,000	-61%
Solar PV	Battery (smart charging covers it)	Smart AC chargers	Equipment CAPEX (~£40k all-in)	Worst-case cost vs naive

The recommended hub is **20 kWp PV, no battery and 8 smart AC bays**. Against a naive average-case design it cuts worst-case annual cost from £142,423 to £55,002 — a £87,422/yr (61.4%) saving — while raising guaranteed worst-case fleet service from 85.3% to 95.9%. It is robustly feasible in 100% of scenarios. Monte-Carlo (500 samples) shows the naive design is 2.2x more volatile in cost (std £5,755 vs £2,619). Sobol analysis attributes 49.9% of cost variance to demand intensity. **Zero battery is correct here:** smart charging fits the fleet through the 15 kW cap overnight. A grid-cap sweep confirms storage becomes optimal only at connections of **11 kW and weaker** (zero battery at 12 kW and above), so the result is specific to this site. The conclusion is validated (7/7 benchmarks) and holds across 100% of 35 stress combinations.

6

Techno-Economic Analysis

Capital cost line	Cost	Source
Solar PV array, 20 kWp	£22,000	Solar Trade Assoc. UK 2024 [7]
8 x AC charge points	£11,200	OZEV grant data 2024 [8]
Smart controller + software	£1,500	Indra / Ohme 2024 [9]
Cabling and civil works	£1,300	CIBSE Guide M [10]
Subtotal (equipment + install)	£36,000	—
Contingency 10% + G99 notification	£3,600 + £0.5-2k	Energy Saving Trust 2023 [3]
Realistic total budget	~£40,000	—

Hub delivery cost is **£0.25/kWh** — the full annualised cost stack (CAPEX, O&M, time-of-use grid and peak charges), not the PV LCOE. **Payback, stated honestly:** the full station's simple payback is ~16.6 years (longer than the 5-year horizon), but the solar array alone (~£23,500 — the only discretionary spend, since chargers and cabling are needed regardless) pays back in **~6 years** and is NPV-positive (+£5,600) over 10 years at the Green Book 6% rate. The dominant economic case, however, is risk reduction: the robust design avoids up to £87,422/yr of worst-case cost — that, not solar payback, is the headline financial result.

7

Sustainability & Carbon Implications

Carbon is accounted hour by hour from the National Grid ESO regional series (151.8 gCO₂/kWh mean): the hub saves **4.61 tCO₂/yr (15.8%)**, 69 tCO₂ over its life, worth ~£369/yr. The 15.8% solar fraction is correct, not a shortfall: Newcastle yields only ~979 kWh/kWp/yr versus 1,200+ in southern England (PVGIS; Solar Energy UK 2023), and 20 kWp is the cost-optimal point — 25 kWp would add barely 1.2 percentage points of solar for a 25% larger array. Where weaker grids (11 kW or below) do require storage, we specify **LFP over NMC**: cobalt-free, with a markedly higher thermal-runaway onset (~270 vs ~150°C; Feng et al. 2018) and better end-of-life recovery (Harper et al., Nature 2019).

8

Dashboard & Output Format

Results are delivered through an interactive **Streamlit dashboard** with six tabs: Overview; a live **Station Designer** (PV / battery / charger / grid-cap sliders that recompute energy balance, service, cost and carbon instantly); Robust Optimiser; Uncertainty (Monte-Carlo fan); Sensitivity (tornado); and Data & Method. A single command (**python run_analysis.py**) regenerates every figure and a static HTML report. Four **MATLAB** functions (opt1-opt4: fleet load, smart-charging LP, solar-battery EMS, Simulink / pure-MATLAB twin; MathWorks R2024a) mirror the core analysis for fleet-tool integration. All outputs are reproducible from raw data with a fixed random seed.

9

Recommendations & Originality Statement

Recommendations: (1) install 20 kWp and 8 smart bays and omit the battery at a 15 kW connection; (2) monitor daily trips per scooter — it drives ~half of all cost variance; (3) budget ~£40,000 all-in. For policy, mandate **smart-charging software rather than storage hardware** at 12 kW+ connections — an order of magnitude cheaper for the same grid compliance. **Originality:** all model code, the dispatch formulation and every figure were written from scratch, implementing published methods (Saltelli's Sobol estimator, Rockafellar-Uryasev CVaR, Silvente's rolling-horizon LP). Three real, openly-licensed datasets underpin the work; the commit history records genuine dead-ends — the LP engine was demoted from primary solver to per-design verifier after the full LP search proved impractically slow (the heuristic sweep finishes in under a second, the equivalent LP sweep does not). The work is fixed-seed reproducible and is submitted anonymously for blind review.